

Not all coexpressions are syncretisms: Limiting Nanosyntax^{*}

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Abstract This paper revises the findings of Dekier (2021) concerning the syncretism and containment of indefinites in light of their semantic implausibility and empirical inadequacy, compared to the alternative semantic approach of Degano & Aloni (2025), and argues against the omnipotence of a nanosyntactic approach to coexpression phenomena. The paper also addresses the diachronic predictions of Nanosyntax and discusses the structure of lexical entries more generally.

Keywords: indefinites, syncretisms, nanosyntax, semantic maps

1 Introduction

This squib aims to put limits on Nanosyntax and the idea of highly articulated feature decomposition. I argue that some coexpressions arise from semantic underspecification rather than from structural containment relations.

As an example of a mistaken nanosyntactic analysis of lexical items, I revise the findings of Dekier (2021) concerning the syncretism and containment of indefinites in light of their semantic implausibility and empirical inadequacy. I present an alternative semantic account of the indefinites' map from Degano & Aloni (2025),¹ which is less problematic and has more predictive power.

In Section 2, I present the indefinites' map and the syncretism patterns it gives rise to. In Section 3, I present Dekier's analysis of these patterns. In Section 4, I discuss the problems with Dekier's analysis. In Section 5, I present a semantic account of the indefinites'

^{*} This is a post-publication author's version of the article. The version of record is Bubnov, G. (2026), "Not all coexpressions are syncretisms: Limiting Nanosyntax", *Glossa: a journal of general linguistics* 11(1), <https://doi.org/10.16995/glossa.25626>, which should be cited. This version corrects a number of errors in the published article and counts as a Correction of it. The corrections are as follows. In Section 5, I correct several terminological and conceptual imprecisions in my presentation of the framework of Degano and Aloni (2025): most importantly, I now use *knownness* rather than *definiteness* for the distinction between known and unknown readings (i.e. whether the speaker knows the referent), and (*epistemically*) *possible world* rather than *epistemic world*; relatedly, the reading labels *indefinite* and *definite* are replaced with *unknown* and *known*, the roles of the world variable v and the empty sequence $\emptyset$ are stated more precisely, and the descriptions of $var(\emptyset, x)$ and $dep(\emptyset, x)$ are corrected. In Section 6, I correct a factual error: the attested instantiation of the diachronic weakening of $dep(v, x)$ is the change from specific unknown (vii) to epistemic (iv) indefinites, not the change from specific (ii) to unmarked (i) indefinites, which instantiates the same weakening but is unattested, as the same paragraph goes on to say. I also clarify that French *quelque* there refers to the *quelque*-series. Additionally, I correct a mistaken citation (Port and Aloni 2015, rather than Aloni and Port 2015, for the diachrony of German *irgend-*), several inaccurate page and volume numbers, and a number of minor typographical and stylistic infelicities. None of these corrections affects the argument or the conclusions of the paper.

¹ Aloni & Degano (2022) is the earlier version of this work. Throughout the paper, I cite the newer version whenever possible.

map from Degano & Aloni (2025). In Section 6, I compare the two accounts, mostly in terms of their diachronic predictions. Then, in Section 7, I discuss the implications of this comparison for grammar architecture. Finally, Section 8 concludes and discusses potential avenues for future research in Nanosyntax.

2 Indefinites' map and syncretism patterns

Dekier proposes that the part of Haspelmath (1997)'s indefinites' map illustrated in Figure 1 can be accounted for in terms of a nanosyntactic (Caha 2009; Starke 2009) approach to syncretism patterns.

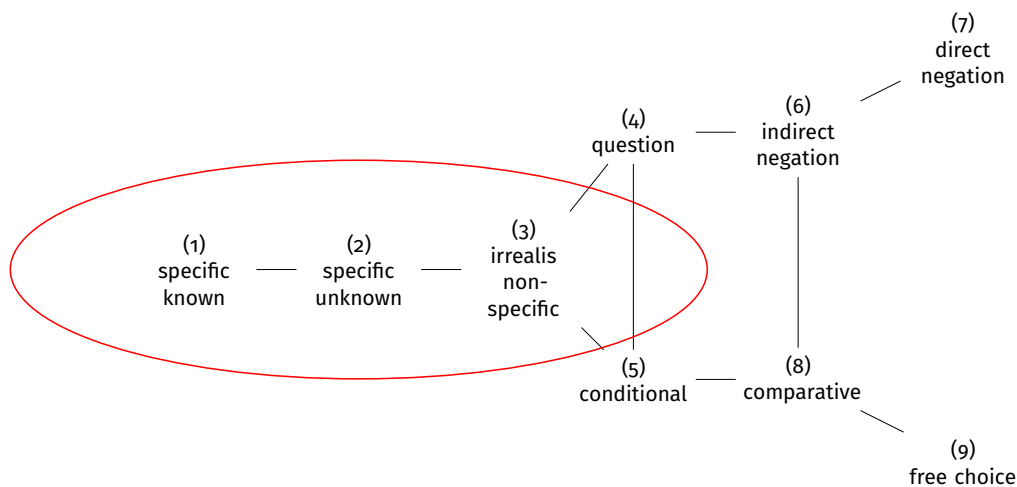


Figure 1: Indefinites' map from Haspelmath (1997)

Haspelmath's map is based on a cross-linguistic survey of indefinites and can be read as follows. The nodes represent different uses/functions of indefinites, and only contiguous nodes can be coexpressed by the same form in a given language.

Our main concern is with (1) *specific known*, (2) *specific unknown*, and (3) *irrealis non-specific* indefinites, which are illustrated in examples (1) from Haspelmath (1997: exx. 5–7).

- (1)
- a. *Specific known*
Somebody called while you were away: guess who!
 - b. *Specific unknown*
I heard **something**, but I couldn't tell what kind of sound it was.
 - c. *Non-specific irrealis*
Please try **somewhere** else.

The first two usages—*specific known* and *specific unknown*—are usages where the DP in question has a specific referent in the world, but the speaker either knows who this referent is (1) or does not (2). The third usage—*non-specific irrealis*—is a usage where the DP in question does not have a specific referent in the world, and its use in Haspelmath (1997) is typically in imperatives.

In English, these three usages are coexpressed by the same form *some*; however, cross-linguistically, this is not always the case. As illustrated in Haspelmath's map, any coexpression pattern is possible as long as it is contiguous on the map. That is, the pattern

where (1) and (3) are coexpressed, but not (2), is not attested. This is illustrated in Table 1.

	non-specific	specific unknown	specific known	pattern
English	some-	some-	some-	AAA
Yakut	-eme	-ere	-ere	ABB
Latin	ali-	ali-	-dam	AAB
Russian	-nibud'	-to	koe-	ABC
unattested				ABA

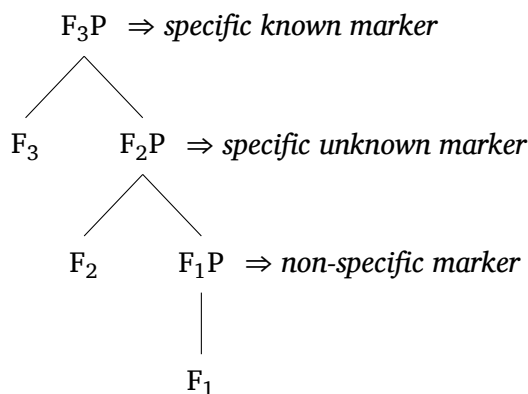
Table 1: Syncretism patterns of indefinites across languages (from Dekier (2021))

In the next section, I present Dekier's analysis of these patterns.

3 Dekier's analysis

Dekier considers such syncretism patterns as an instance of a broader *ABA generalization (Bobaljik 2012),² which states that the ABA pattern is unattested in hierarchically ordered sequences. For the indefinites, Dekier proposes the structure in (2).

(2) Indefinite hierarchy (Dekier 2021)



This tree states that the *specific known* indefinite contains the features of both the *specific unknown* and *non-specific* indefinites, while the *specific unknown* indefinite contains the features of the *non-specific* indefinite.

Dekier explicitly presents only one semantic argument for this hierarchy, as opposed to the reverse one, which would also comply with the *ABA generalization. It is based on the semantic properties of the indefinites. The *specific known* usage is the most complex one, since its semantics involves both the existence of a specific referent in the world and the speaker's knowledge of this referent. The *specific unknown* usage is less complex, since it only involves the existence of a specific referent in the world, but not the speaker's knowledge of this referent. Finally, the *non-specific* usage is the least complex, since it does not involve a specific referent in the world at all.

For the hierarchical ordering, Dekier's work provides additional supporting evidence. Lexical gaps in indefinite pronouns start from the *specific known* indefinites and expand to the *non-specific* indefinites, as illustrated in Table 2.

² Dekier's generalization is based on a 45-language sample, primarily taken from Haspelmath (1997).

	non-specific	specific unknown	specific known	pattern
Kannada	-aadaruu	-oo	–	AB
Quechua	-pis/-pas	-chi/-cha	–	AB
Mandarin Chinese	wh-pronoun	–	–	A
Irish	–	–	–	–
Swahili	–	–	–	–
Filipino	–	–	–	–
unattested				ABA

Table 2: Paradigm gaps (Dekier 2021)

Dekier says that the gaps are expected if the hierarchy in (2) is correct, since if a less complex indefinite is not lexicalized in a language, the more complex indefinites would not be lexicalized either. Otherwise, the lexical entry that spells out the more complex indefinite could also spell out the less complex indefinite due to the Nanosyntactic Superset Principle.

In the next section, I discuss the problems with Dekier’s analysis.

4 Problems with Dekier’s analysis

The main shortcoming of Dekier’s hierarchy, as noted by Dekier (2021) himself, is that no actual morphological containment pattern is attested in the indefinites. However, the nanosyntactic approach suggests that there should be such patterns if the features F_2 or F_3 from the hierarchy in (2) are spelled out by distinct exponents. This raises the question of why they never are.³

The semantic argument for the proposed hierarchy is not particularly compelling; it appears to be largely stipulative and only gains plausibility if one presupposes a hierarchical structure whose orientation remains to be determined. As will be discussed in Section 5, the semantics of indefinites can be, and arguably are better, accounted for within an alternative framework in which the *specific unknown* indefinite is the most complex, while the other two types are less complex, albeit in distinct ways.

The paradigm gaps argument seems to be the most solid one theoretically; however, the absence of the ABA pattern is based on just three languages with partial gaps and three languages with complete gaps. It is not clear how robust this generalization is and whether it can be considered a real argument in favor of the hierarchy in (2).

In the next section, I present a semantic account of the indefinites’ map from Degano & Aloni (2025) and show that it is empirically more adequate and semantically more plausible than the one from Dekier (2021).

³ A reviewer suggests that if we adopt Vanden Wyngaerd (2018)’s Revised Superset Principle, which treats sets of features as flat, we could explain the absence of morphological containment in these patterns, provided the structures for indefinites are not nested within each other. However, this is not entirely satisfactory: even if the feature sequence of one indefinite is so intervened by other features in another indefinite’s functional sequence that the morphological realization of the first indefinite has many more features than any constituent in the second indefinite—such that the Elsewhere Principle almost always makes another morphological realization a better candidate—we would still expect to see cases where two indefinites, although not containing each other, share a common exponent for some common feature. Whether there are such cases is an empirical question that deserves further research.

5 Semantic account

Degano & Aloni (2025), following the less formalized work of Farkas & Brasoveanu (2020), propose that knownness and specificity can be united (and thus the indefinites' map can be explained) in terms of **variation** and **constancy** of the denotation of the DP in question. Their account is based on their version of team semantics (Hodges 1997; Väänänen 2007), and in what follows I present their account in a simplified way, appealing to possible worlds, and discuss its implications.

According to Degano & Aloni (2025), indefinites, in addition to existential quantification, also exhibit **variation** and **constancy** restrictions on their denotation. **Variation** and **constancy** are calculated globally in the case of **knownness** and within a given epistemically possible world in the case of **specificity**. **Variation** gives us unknown and non-specific readings, while **constancy** gives us known and specific readings. The **variation** and **constancy** are captured by two atomic formulas: $var(y,x)$ and $dep(y,x)$. The first one means that x varies with respect to y , that is, there are at least two assignments where x takes different values when y is held constant; the second one means that x depends on y , that is, for each assignment x takes the same value when y is held constant.

To describe the distribution of indefinites, we instantiate y as either v (the designated world variable, whose values are the worlds compatible with the speaker's knowledge) or $\emptyset$ (the empty sequence, i.e. no relativization at all). Thus, $dep(v,x)$ means that x has exactly one value within each epistemically possible world, but can vary across the worlds, while $var(v,x)$ means that x has at least two different values within at least one epistemically possible world. Meanwhile, $\emptyset$ removes the relativization altogether: $var(\emptyset,x)$ requires only that x take different values in at least two assignments, no matter which worlds those assignments involve, while $dep(\emptyset,x)$ requires that x take the same value in all assignments.

TYPE	SK	SU	NS	REQUIREMENT	EXAMPLE
(i) unmarked	✓	✓	✓	none	Italian <i>qualcuno</i>
(ii) specific	✓	✓	✗	$dep(v,x)$	Georgian <i>-ghats</i>
(iii) non-specific	✗	✗	✓	$var(v,x)$	Russian <i>-nibud'</i>
(iv) epistemic	✗	✓	✓	$var(\emptyset,x)$	German <i>irgend-</i>
(v) specific known	✓	✗	✗	$dep(\emptyset,x)$	Russian <i>koe-</i>
(vi) SK + NS	✓	✗	✓	$dep(\emptyset,x) \vee var(v,x)$	unattested
(vii) specific unknown	✗	✓	✗	$dep(v,x) \wedge var(\emptyset,x)$	Kannada <i>-oo</i>

Table 3: Types of indefinites adapted from Degano & Aloni (2025)

Crucially, this analysis considers the indefinites that can express several functions not as syncretic forms, but as single forms with a less restrictive semantics that allows them to occur in several contexts. For example, the unmarked indefinite (i) can occur in all three contexts because it does not impose any restriction on the denotation of the DP in question. The specific indefinite (ii) can occur in both specific contexts because it imposes a restriction on the denotation of the DP in question within each possible world, but not globally. The epistemic indefinite (iv) can occur in both unknown contexts because it imposes a restriction on the denotation of the DP in question to have at least two different values globally, but not necessarily within each possible world.

The unattested indefinite (vi) is predicted to be unattested because the requirements it imposes are contradictory and can only be posited in a disjunctive way.

In the next section, I compare the two accounts and present additional predictions of both accounts in terms of diachrony.

6 Comparison of the two accounts

The semantic account presented above offers clear advantages over Dekier’s nanosyntactic approach. Furthermore, the semantic account makes two additional predictions. First, the specific unknown indefinite (vii) is predicted to be attested but less frequent than the other indefinites because it imposes a conjunction of two requirements on the denotation of the DP in question, which makes it more complex than the other indefinites. This prediction is borne out, as noted in [Degano & Aloni \(2025: 973\)](#).

The second prediction concerns diachronic changes. [Haspelmath \(1997\)](#) describes several attested diachronic changes involving indefinites relevant for us.

Extension from SU to the right. This type of change is from specific unknown indefinites (vii) to epistemic indefinites (iv) ([Haspelmath 1997: ch. 6.4.4](#)), as illustrated in [Figure 2](#). This change is evidenced in indefinites that are etymologically derived from expressions with meanings like ‘I don’t know’, and their original use implies that the speaker could know the referent (that is, they are specific), but does not (that is, they are unknown) ([Haspelmath 1997: ch. 6.2.1](#)). This type is exemplified by Lithuanian *kaž*-, Albanian *di*-, and older German *neiz*- ([Haspelmath 1997: 153](#)).

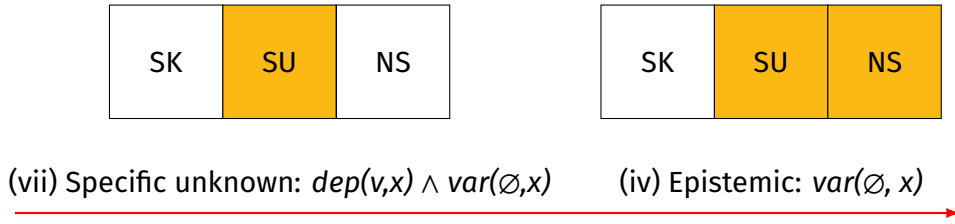


Figure 2: Diachronic change from SU to the right

Extension from NS to the left. Several indefinites ([Haspelmath 1997: ch. 6.4.2](#)), given their etymology, originally were used in ‘free choice’ contexts, which are connected to the specific known and specific unknown usages via the non-specific one, according to Haspelmath’s map, see [Figure 1](#); thus, for us such indefinites’ extension to the left means extension from non-specific indefinites (iii). Among the relevant cases is the French unmarked indefinite (i) *quelque*-series ([Haspelmath 1997](#)).⁴ Additionally, the change from the non-specific indefinite (iii) is instantiated by the German epistemic indefinite (iv) *irgend*- ([Port & Aloni 2015](#)). This type of change is illustrated in [Figure 3](#).

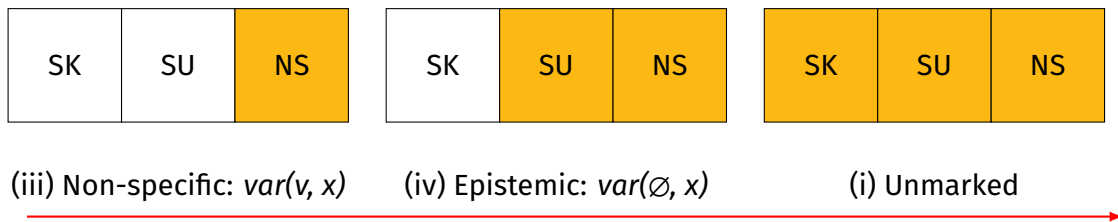


Figure 3: Diachronic change from NS to the left

⁴ Stipulatively, as Haspelmath says himself, the Czech specific marker *-si* may also be of this origin.

The semantic account allows us to predict the extension both to the left and to the right. Aloni & Degano (2022: 200–201) note that the account predicts that the non-specific indefinite (iii) can develop into the epistemic indefinite (iv) because the requirement $var(v,x)$ entails and can be weakened via diachronic change to $var(\emptyset,x)$. Diachronic weakening from $var(\emptyset,x)$ to no restriction, and from $dep(v,x)$ to no restriction, is also observed. This is instantiated, respectively, by the attested changes from epistemic indefinites (iv) to unmarked indefinites (i) and from specific unknown indefinites (vii) to epistemic indefinites (iv)—from the conjunction $dep(v,x) \wedge var(\emptyset,x)$ to $var(\emptyset,x)$.⁵ The semantic approach also predicts changes from specific indefinites (ii) to unmarked indefinites (i) and from specific known indefinites (v) to specific indefinites (ii), both of which are unattested. However, given that we have only a few clear cases of diachronic change, this may reflect a lack of data. The crucial point is that all attested changes instantiate semantic weakening, independent of their direction (which would be crucial for a hierarchical Nanosyntactic approach), as predicted by the semantic account.

Diachronic Nanosyntax is not yet developed, and we do not know what changes lexical entries can undergo; thus, it is not a straightforward task to compare predictions of two approaches on diachrony. However, given that we know that words become obsolete, we can legitimately assume that the loss of a lexical entry is an option for diachronic change. Given this, the Nanosyntactic account could predict only part of what the semantic account predicts, taking into account the Elsewhere and Superset Principles (Caha 2009; Starke 2009). Consider the following case, illustrated in examples (3)–(4). If a language initially had two lexical entries, one spelling out F_1 and the other spelling out F_2 and F_1 , then if the entry spelling out just F_1 is lost, the entry spelling out both F_2 and F_1 could spell out just F_1 due to the Superset Principle. This would lead to a change from the specific unknown indefinite (vii) to the epistemic indefinite (iv).

- (3) Initial state
- a. Lexical entries
 - (i) $A \Leftrightarrow [F_1]$
 - (ii) $B \Leftrightarrow [F_2 [F_1]]$
 - b. Spelling out
 - (i) Non-specific $[F_1] \Rightarrow A$
 - (ii) Specific unknown $[F_2 [F_1]] \Rightarrow B$
- (4) Loss of A
- a. Lexical entries
 - (i) –
 - (ii) $B \Leftrightarrow [F_2 [F_1]]$
 - b. Spelling out
 - (i) Non-specific $[F_1] \Rightarrow B$
 - (ii) Specific unknown $[F_2 [F_1]] \Rightarrow B$

Thus, Nanosyntax by default predicts that as a diachronic change, a lexical entry could gain the ability to spell out a subset of what it originally could, and Nanosyntax would

⁵ Aloni and Degano themselves restrict diachronic change to atomic weakening only, thereby precluding changes from $var(\emptyset,x)$ to no restriction (i.e. from epistemic indefinites (iv) to unmarked indefinites (i)), because they take this change to be unattested (Aloni & Degano 2022: 200). They diverge from Haspelmath by claiming that Portuguese *algum* cannot be used as a specific known indefinite, whereas Haspelmath (1997: ex. A49) shows that it can. However, as noted above, French *quelque* also instantiates this change.

not predict the attested change in the reverse direction.⁶ In this way, Nanosyntax would also predict a change from specific known (v) to specific (ii) indefinites, and consequently from specific (ii) to unmarked indefinites (i), both unattested. The semantic approach in fact mispredicts these changes as well, as noted above.⁷

The general point is that if we had a hierarchical structure for indefinites as proposed by Dekier (2021), we would expect to see a unidirectional diachronic change pattern, from more complex indefinites to less complex ones, as is the case for direction > recipient (see Caha (2017) for hierarchy and Haspelmath (2003) for diachrony), or comitative > instrument (see Caha (2009) for hierarchy and Narrog (2010) for diachrony). However, as we have seen, the attested changes for indefinites go in both directions, which is unexpected under the nanosyntactic approach.

These empirical advantages of the semantic account over the nanosyntactic one raise broader questions about the architecture of grammar and the role of syntax versus semantics in accounting for coexpression patterns.

7 Grammar architecture

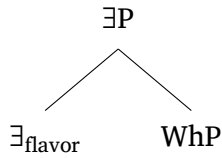
I suggest that the plausibility of the semantic account demonstrates that it is not the case that all coexpressions should be analyzed as spellouts of subconstituents of a complex syntactic structure, but rather that sometimes they are just spellouts of non-hierarchically structured nodes. This is not to say that Nanosyntax cannot account for syncretism patterns, but rather that it should not be the default approach to all coexpression phenomena, and that **semantics** should not be neglected.

There are two options for how to model the structure of indefinites in the proposed way. The first one is to posit that in syntax there are different terminal or non-terminal $\exists$ nodes not related to each other by any featural containment and coming with pairs of lexical entries, as in examples (5)–(7) for Russian AB(B/C)⁸ indefinites (Haspelmath 1997: 65).

⁶ As suggested by an anonymous reviewer, we can propose that, as a diachronic change, a lexical entry can expand: instead of $A \Leftrightarrow [F_1]$, we obtain $A \Leftrightarrow [F_2 [F_1]]$. This, in combination with the loss of lexical entry B or the presence of only the more specified lexical entry $C \Leftrightarrow [F_3 [F_2 [F_1]]]$, would yield the expected diachronic change from the non-specific indefinite (iii) to the epistemic indefinite (iv). Although this provides a way to predict the second direction of this change, I leave the investigation of whether the expansion of a lexical entry constitutes a legitimate diachronic change for future research.

⁷ Reviewers suggest that the hierarchical relationship among indefinites may be preserved but reversed relative to Dekier's proposal, i.e. the non-specific indefinite contains the specific unknown indefinite, which in turn contains the specific known indefinite. Under this reversed hierarchy, the semantically predicted attested change from non-specific indefinites (iii) to epistemic indefinites (iv), the semantically predicted attested change from epistemic indefinites (iv) to unmarked indefinites (i), and the semantically predicted unattested change from specific unknown (vii) to specific indefinites (ii) would be expected. However, the semantically predicted attested change from specific unknown (vii) to epistemic indefinites (iv) and the semantically predicted unattested change from specific indefinites (ii) to unmarked indefinites (i) would then be unexpected. Thus, the reversed hierarchy is somewhat more plausible than Dekier's with respect to diachronic change, although not more so relative to the semantic approach. Additionally, such a hierarchy is more in line with Middleton (2020; 2021)'s findings on the structural relationship between anaphors, diaphors, and pronominals. The hierarchy anaphor > diaphor > pronominal is supported by clear morphological containment cases, and in it the more complex structure corresponds to a less constant denotation (i.e. pronominals are free, diaphors are bound, and anaphors are locally bound). A reversed hierarchy for indefinites would be similar in that the more complex structure would likewise correspond to a less constant denotation. However, given the absence of morphological containment patterns in indefinites, I leave this line of reasoning for future research.

⁸ For languages that, in a hierarchical account, would be analyzed as exhibiting syncretism—for example, AAA languages like English, where the same exponent *some-* is used in all three contexts, as well as ABB or AAB languages, where there are only two exponents for three contexts—if we treat coexpressions not as

(5) Different $\exists$ nodes

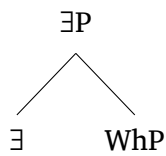
(6) Phonological entries

- a. /koe-/ $\Leftrightarrow \exists_{\text{specific known}}$
 b. /-to/ $\Leftrightarrow \exists_{\text{epistemic}}$
 c. /-nibud'/ $\Leftrightarrow \exists_{\text{non-specific}}$

(7) Semantic entries⁹

- a. $\exists_{\text{specific known}} \Leftrightarrow \exists x \cap \text{dep}(\emptyset, x)$
 b. $\exists_{\text{epistemic}} \Leftrightarrow \exists x \cap \text{var}(\emptyset, x)$
 c. $\exists_{\text{non-specific}} \Leftrightarrow \exists x \cap \text{var}(v, x)$

Another option is to propose that there exists only one $\exists$ node, as illustrated in examples (8)–(9), which comes with lexical entries that are form–syntax–meaning triples.

(8) Unique $\exists$ node

(9) Lexical entries

- a. $\langle \text{/koe-/, } \exists, \exists x \cap \text{dep}(\emptyset, x) \rangle$
 b. $\langle \text{/-to/, } \exists, \exists x \cap \text{var}(\emptyset, x) \rangle$
 c. $\langle \text{/-nibud'/, } \exists, \exists x \cap \text{var}(v, x) \rangle$

The second option is contra Preminger (2021)’s non-semiotic approach, which, based on idioms, claims that forms should not be assumed to (directly) have meanings, but rather that all lexical entries are either syntax-form or syntax-meaning mappings. Thus, this option (if it is to be aligned with Preminger’s findings) requires two different types of lexical entries, since idioms of the type discussed by Preminger (2021) would still need to be accounted for. Traditional Nanosyntax itself follows (or at least is compatible with) the non-semiotic approach for functional elements, which are decomposed into features, but it utilizes semiotic entries for roots, which are assumed to have lexical meanings—as triples in the sense of Ramchand (2008); Vanden Wyngaerd et al. (2020); Vanden Wyngaerd & De Clercq & Caha (2021). If the indefinites data are to be analyzed in line with Nanosyntax, this suggests that the $\exists$ head should be treated as a root.

The data from indefinites provide evidence for the first option. There are cases of morphologically complex indefinites that, however, are not in morphological containment relations with other indefinites. This is exemplified by the Russian non-specific marker *-nibud'*, which consists of the negative marker *ni* and the subjunctive form *bud'* of the verb *byt'* ‘to be’. This suggests that the $\exists$ nodes are complex and complex in different ways, which means that they themselves are different from each other.

Although the choice between the two options for indefinites is probably the first one, it is unclear whether this can be generalized to other cases of coexpression phenomena of a non-syntactic nature. I leave this question for future research.

8 Conclusion

In this paper, I have argued against the universal applicability of the nanosyntactic approach to coexpression phenomena, using indefinite pronouns as a test case. I have shown that Dekier (2021)’s nanosyntactic analysis of indefinites faces serious empirical

syncretisms but as cases of semantic underspecification, we still end up with only one or two lexical entries (or, in this case, pairs of entries), respectively, just as under a hierarchical structure like Dekier’s.

⁹ Here and below, I use an informal notation to represent the bundle of the existential core and semantic restrictions in the lexical entry, rather than a strict semantic formula.

and theoretical problems: it fails to account for the absence of morphological containment patterns, relies on a weak semantic argument for feature hierarchy, and makes incorrect predictions about diachronic change.

In contrast, the semantic account of [Degano & Aloni \(2025\)](#), which treats indefinites as lexical items with varying degrees of semantic restrictiveness rather than as syncretic spellouts of complex feature structures, provides a more empirically adequate and theoretically sound explanation of the attested patterns. Crucially, this account better predicts the observed diachronic changes and the relative frequency of different indefinite types.

The broader implication of this comparison is that coexpressions cannot be reduced to PF alone: different contexts in which the same exponent is used need not be derived from distinct syntactic structures, but may instead be epiphenomena of semantic underspecification at LF.

Nevertheless, there are clear cases where Nanosyntax seems to be the best approach. Some of the phenomena investigated within Nanosyntax clearly exhibit morphological containment patterns and are thus best analyzed with Nanosyntax. For example, this is evident in works on case ([Caha 2009; 2017; Starke 2017; Caha 2018; 2019](#))¹⁰, locational case ([Pantcheva 2011](#)), comparatives ([Caha & De Clercq & Vanden Wyngaerd 2019; Vanden Wyngaerd et al. 2020; De Clercq et al. 2022](#)), numerals ([Wągiel & Caha 2020; 2021](#)), number ([Caha 2022](#)), persons ([Vanden Wyngaerd 2018](#)), verb actionality ([Caha & De Clercq & Vanden Wyngaerd 2023](#)), and ontological categories ([Baunaz & Lander 2018b](#)).

Other research in Nanosyntax explores paradigms, which, by definition, require featural combination and cannot be modeled otherwise; see, among others, [Taraldsen \(2019\); Caha \(2021\); Cortiula \(2025\)](#).

Complementizers ([Baunaz 2018; Wiland 2018; Baunaz & Lander 2018a](#)), imperfective aspect ([Starke 2021; Dikmen & Demirok 2025](#)), and negation ([De Clercq 2020](#)) are not clear cases. As far as I am aware, there are no cases of morphological containment presented for complementizers and aspect and only partial morphological containment for negation markers, but this may be due to the limited data available. This cannot be said of [Dekier \(2021\)](#), who bases his analysis on large typological data from [Haspelmath \(1997\)](#).

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¹⁰ Although case syncretisms represent a non-trivial challenge for Nanosyntax (see [Zompì \(2019\)](#) for criticism), it is clear that it is a good approach.

Competing interests

The author has no competing interests to declare.

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